J&K was stripped of its special status and bifurcated into Union territories, even the Centre has repeatedly called its UT status temporary and return of statehood a solemn promise—to be fulfilled at an "appropriate time".

Why, then, did the chief secretary and law secretary hasten to write to the Speaker before the debate, advising against taking up the resolution proposed to be moved by CM Omar Abdullah? Well, its historical references carried weight, even if the wording was restrained. The text did not explicitly demand restoration of special status, but it recalled two prior resolutions: a precursor from November 2024, from right after Omar's government came in; and more significantly, the autonomy resolution adopted on June 26, 2000, under Farooq Abdullah's National Conference government.

Takeaways

- **J&K assembly passes resolution for statehood**
- **Long wait for promise fufilment led to pressure**
- **Text refers to 2000 autonomy resolution**

That 2000 resolution had endorsed a 1999 State Autonomy Committee report seeking a return to J&K's pre-1953 position. That meant returning all subjects of governance except defence, foreign affairs, currency and communication. Drawing on the 1952 Delhi Agreement, it also proposed redesignating the Governor as Sadr-e-Riyasat and the CM as Wazir-e-Azam. Delicate territory, and the Atal Bihari Vajpayee cabinet had duly met it with a rejection. So, Omar tiptoed across it, merely appending references to them, not calling for a fresh vote on those demands. Just for a subtle echo to hang in the air.

Chance of autonomy being sub-zero now, why even bother? "The NC is under tremendous pressure from the people as also from vocal dissenters, like MP Ruhullah Mehdi," says Prof. Sheikh Showkat Hussain, former head, School of Legal Studies, Central University of Kashmir. The wait for statehood has been frustratingly long. New Delhi's open-ended timetable leaves an electoral promise unfulfilled, and curbs the NC dispensation's capacity to govern by vesting powers in the Lieutenant Governor. He feels the resolution is a symbolic protest against that "helplessness"—having pro forma power "without any capacity to exert it".

COMPROMISE TEXT

Omar played it with dead hands, dropping proposed amendments by at least six NC legislators who sought to explicitly insert Articles 370 and 35A in the text. "The careful wording and relatively soft reference to autonomy was probably a compromise to secure the support of non-BJP parties," says political scientist Noor Ahmad Baba. Silencing critics who accused them of reneging on promises was, in Hussain's view, a primary objective. But Omar's two resolutions, in his view, also negate New Delhi's claim of having the legislature's "concurrence" for revoking special status.

The chief secretary's preventive dash, which Baba calls "bureaucratic overreach", also offered Omar a chance to dial up the resistance a notch. Hussain felt it "reflected the real worth of the UT legislature"—implying it was "too small a body" to take up such issues. Thus, he says, "The passing of the resolution itself became a process of reassertion." ■



▶ GOA

YATRA OF H

The party revs its ground force with a

By **Dhaval S. Kulkarni**

IT'S NOT ONLY IN DELHI THAT THE CONGRESS HAS suddenly hit the streets. Boots on the ground, many of them, is how it's approaching next year's electoral test in Goa, where it will have stared gloomily at sunsets for 15 long years by then. A 27-day padayatra, trudging through all 40 assembly constituencies, is offering a Delhi-like narrative of surging volumes despite the odd denial of permission—enough for it to become a point of contention in itself. "Paid crowds," alleged the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP). "Tremendous grassroots response," claims an enthused Congress—already imagining an allegorical march that crosses over into the treasury benches.

On its home stretch to October 18, the 'Goy Rakhonn Yatra' (or 'Save Goa March') has surely stirred up some dust. Rahul Gandhi was due on October 12—but he had a pressing appointment in New Delhi! Yet, the profile was high enough. Telangana chief minister Revanth Reddy walked at the head of a throng on October 11 at Cuncolim on a revised route, after the administration suddenly debarred NH-